

these three “key transformative transition areas”.

Digital transformation: Policymakers identified this as key to ensuring the “transfer of ideas, opportunities, and information”. The vast amount of data generated by these technologies can be used for effective policymaking and successful public service delivery. To further these principles, India is launching “Data for Development Capacity Building Initiative” to support capacity building and train policymakers, officials and other relevant stakeholders from developing countries.

The agenda document also calls for the responsible use of artificial intelligence (AI). This includes providing scope for remedies “and processes to report discrimination and correct automated decision-making based on human errors and biases, as well as biased data”. This, it suggests, will increase transparency and accountability in AI approaches.

Just transitions: Recognising that the transition pathways to global net-zero targets have so far translated to high costs and risk premiums for some, the Development Working Group has called for promoting sustainable, inclusive and just transitions globally, leaving no one behind. “Creating a stronger international enabling environment that is proactive, adaptive, and responsive to the needs and priorities of all countries is critical to making the multilateral system better suited to the challenges of the 21st century,” says Davinder Sandhu, Co-founder and Chairman of Primus Partners, a business and management consulting firm.

Gender equality: It is here that the working group has gone into the most detail on addressing imbalances. This action plan focusses on women-led development that entails re-imagining women as active members of society through full, effective and meaningful participation in the economy and as decision-makers. It has four pillars: economic and social empowerment; bridging the digital divide; environment and climate action; and women’s food security and nutrition.

The choice of these agenda items is an acknowledgement of how they influence and intersect with all the SDGs. For example, while countries might have substantial economic data, they need to lay emphasis on gathering quality data that is gender-disaggregated, accounting for regions that may be lagging behind. This data is essential to assess, plan, and implement effective actions. Countries have been encouraged to tailor these principles to suit their local conditions.

KEY TO SUCCESS

Though the agenda document represents some progress, the task ahead is still daunting and requires concerted action. They will require the collaboration of lo-

cal governments, stakeholders, and even the private sector at the national and regional levels.

This fact was also highlighted by United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) India, which is working closely with the NITI Aayog, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MOSPI), and several state governments on the SDGs. It says governments need to strengthen national and sub-national capacity and accountability. The NITI Aayog and MOSPI, which are spearheading India’s SDG agenda, did not respond to *Business Today*’s queries.

Meenakshi Kathel, Chief Advisor, Strategic Planning and State Outreach of UNDP India, explains, “Countries need to use SDGs as a prescriptive framework to push for an interconnected approach (between economic, social, and environmental pillars) and an LNOB lens, and not reduce it to a monitoring or tracking metric. The Indian model of SDG localisation is a



With a population of over 1.4 billion, India will be the driving force for the UN’s SDG agenda

| 89

good example that can be adapted by other countries.” For this to happen, the SDGs need to be institutionalised following a whole-of-government approach. Kathel adds that investment in data infrastructure and capacities is critical to ensuring evidence-based decision-making and correctly identifying solutions.

Other areas that need attention are the availability and accessibility of high-quality data, new and emerging technologies—including big data, AI, and machine learning—and integrating them with traditional data sources. Importantly, the SDG targets need to be integrated into government budgets for an impact- or results-oriented budgeting mechanism. It is essential to link SDG costing and financing gap analysis with investment by exploring fiscal space and other innovative financing tools. And lastly, India needs to recognise the role of partnerships—including South-